

▲ JU students burn V-C Abhijit Chakraborty's effigy demanding his resignation, Dec. 24, 2014

GETTY IMAGES

Rohith Vemula's death by suicide in 2016 sparked a nationwide protest against the discrimination and violence meted out to the Dalit community. A student at the University of Hyderabad, Vemula had hanged himself, leaving behind a chilling note in which he called his birth a "fatal accident". Touching a raw nerve among the student community, demonstrations across campuses in the country reiterated the demand for equal rights and opportunities for Dalits and religious minorities as provided for in the Indian Constitution.

The protests alerted Indians to the fact that despite the enactment of a range of legislations meant to protect Dalits, discrimination and segregation remain rampant. Neither the political regime, nor the ideology of the ruling political party, or the presence of major Dalit parties within states makes a difference.

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As per the National Crime Records Bureau data for 2020, more atrocities are committed against the scheduled castes and scheduled tribes in the Hindi heartland states of Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan, Bihar and Uttar Pradesh. It also revealed that the absence of social reform movements in these states has contributed to brutal caste wars. Part of the reason for this is the backlash by privileged groups against a new form of assertion of rights by Dalit youth. ■

– Amarnath K. Menon

A HISTORY OF OPPRESSION
Discrimination, as perceived earlier, isn't a rural problem alone. Joblessness among Dalits runs through the urban landscape as well.